Investigating interactions

Prototype for review; outside runtime discovery.

The aim is to explain what happens when mechanics meet, and whether that interaction matters in practice. Keep three questions distinct: what the rules say, what follows from those rules, and what observed play supports.

Form an explanation worth testing

Identify the claimed interaction and the behavior it is supposed to produce. “These work well together” is a starting point, not an explanation. Work toward a concrete account of what one element supplies and how another uses it.

Read the relevant effects and restrictions from available factual sources. Track conditions such as effect type, trigger, recipient, duration, stacking, and caps where they matter. Do not fill gaps in wording with remembered rules from another patch. Identify an unresolved rule explicitly if it determines whether the interaction exists.

Trace the mechanism

Follow the proposed chain from trigger to effect. Separate direct statements from deductions. If several steps depend on unverified behavior, retain them as hypotheses rather than combining them into a confident conclusion.

Look for the limiting step. A combination may function as described but have little value because its trigger is infrequent, its benefit arrives too late, another effect already supplies the benefit, or using it displaces something more valuable. These are questions to investigate, not assumptions about the named combination.

Consider the boundary cases that distinguish explanations. If the proposed mechanism is correct, where should its benefit diminish or disappear? A useful boundary makes the explanation more specific than “strong things are strong together.”

Connect the mechanism to observations

Choose evidence capable of addressing the remaining uncertainty. Rules can establish eligibility; an explicit source account may describe behavior; holder or cohort results may describe outcomes. None automatically answers the others.

When using aggregate results, preserve the relevant holder and context. Compare alternatives that address the hypothesis, and account for differing investment or correlated board strength where the tools permit. Co-occurrence may reflect access or convention. A strong combined result does not by itself establish an extra benefit from the interaction.

If the decisive question requires combat observation or an unavailable rule, identify that missing evidence. Do not imply a simulation or in-game test was performed. A supported mechanical deduction can still be useful without an estimate of its placement value.

Explain what survives

Present the mechanism, its enabling conditions, and its main limit. Distinguish verified rules, supported deductions, observed associations, and unresolved questions in natural prose. Explain the practical implication only as far as those pieces support it.

Stop when the interaction is explained, disproved, or narrowed to a specific unknown. Avoid extending an interesting interaction into a build recommendation unless the evidence also supports the opportunity cost of using it.